The Architecture of Carrierless Continuity

Deconstructing the Metaphysics of Flow: Dependent Designation, Tsongkhapa's Mere I, and the Vivid Instant

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Summary

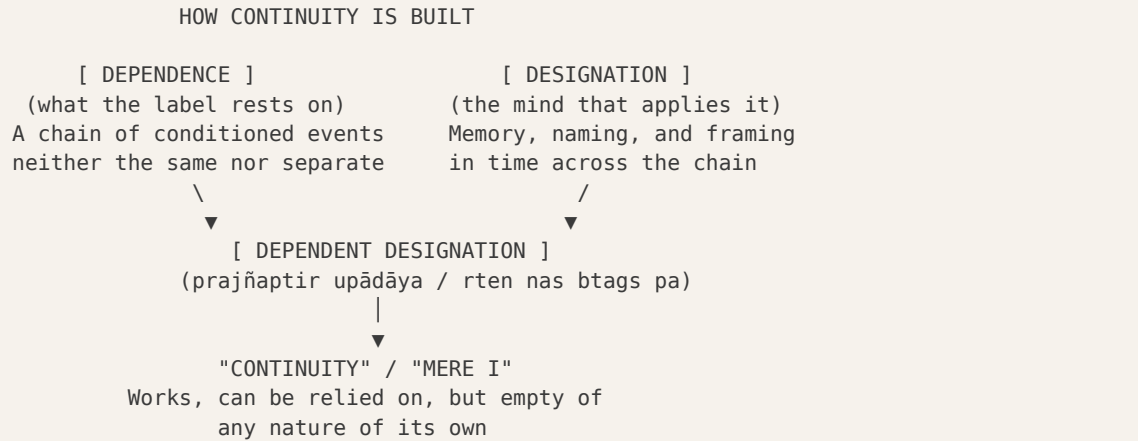
Common sense and most traditional philosophy share an unspoken belief: that **continuity** is built into reality itself. On this picture, time is like a river that flows whether or not anyone is watching. And if something is to stay "the same" over time, there must be a fixed *carrier* that holds its identity together: a soul, a lasting self, a core in the brain, or physical energy that is conserved.

This article draws on John Tan's (*Thusness*) *Death and Continuity*, on related texts from *The Logical Necessity of a Substrateless World*, and on the Middle Way (Prāsaṅgika-Madhyamaka) reasoning of Nāgārjuna and Je Tsongkhapa. It makes three points:

1. **Continuity is not simply given; it is designated.** Continuity needs two things together: **dependence** (one conditioned event following on from another) and **designation** (a label applied across that chain of events). Neither one alone gives continuity. Together, they are what Tsongkhapa calls the **mere I** (*nga tsam*).
2. **When designating stops, no continuum appears.** In deep sleep, under general anaesthesia, or in the raw moment of a sensation before any thought, no hidden thread of time flows in secret, and none is found when we look for it. Yet the continuity is not wiped out of everyday reality. The clock, the surgeon and, once she wakes, the patient herself can all correctly say that three hours passed.
3. **Designation seen as empty.** Seeing that continuity is *only designated* does not destroy everyday life. What it removes is the habit of treating life as something we own and death as the theft of it. What is left is a continuity that can change as far as its conditions allow: promises still hold, habits can loosen, and each appearance is met fresh, vivid and unobstructed (*ma 'gags pa*).

1. The Two Pillars: Why Continuity Needs Both "Dependence" and "Designation"

Continuity is not something we simply perceive, like a colour. It is designated, and it rests on two pillars. Take either one away and there is no continuity to talk about.



1.1 Dependence (*pratītya* / *rten nas*)

A label of continuity cannot be stuck onto thin air. It needs a chain of conditions, where each later stage arises in dependence on earlier ones.

- A rice sprout grows from a rice seed, not from an acorn.
- The candle flame at midnight depends on the flame at dusk, and on oil and oxygen burning all the while.

But this chain **carries no traveller**. The seed does not crawl into the sprout. The dusk flame does not ride into the midnight flame. Nothing passes from one stage to the next.

1.2 Designation (*prajñapti* / *btags pa*)

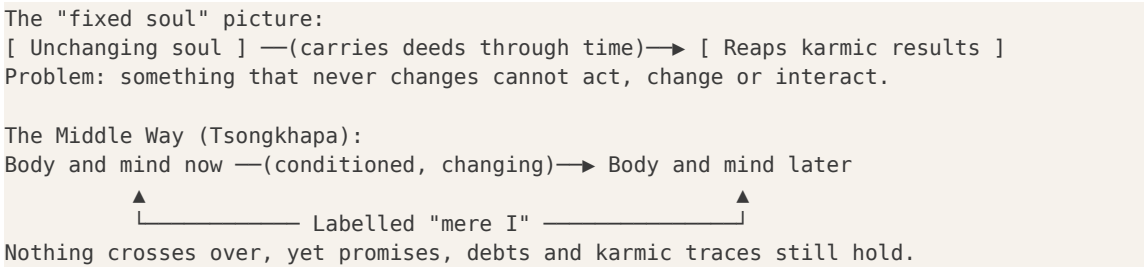
A chain of conditions on its own is not yet "continuity". The moments have to be gathered together, a boundary drawn around them, and the whole named as *one ongoing thing*:

- We call the burning candle **"the same flame burning all night."**
- We call a series of separate sound vibrations **"a melody."**
- We call the child, the teenager and the ageing adult **"the same person."**

The key point: continuity is not a wire that already exists and that the label merely wraps up. **The designation is the continuity.** It is not a cover laid over some hidden flow. Take the designation away, and the "continuum" does not stay behind as a fact standing by itself. But it does not drop out of existence either. Everyday existence is settled by convention, by what is fit to be known, not by whether one particular mind happens to be naming it right now.

2. Je Tsongkhapa's "Mere I" (*nga tsam*)

This settles the old puzzle of personal identity and karma. It does so without an eternal soul (*ātman*) and without sliding into moral nihilism, the view that nothing we do carries consequences (*uccheda-vāda*).



2.1 Identity Without a Fixed Carrier

Traditional philosophies assumed that if you are to be responsible for a promise made twenty years ago, some unchanging core in you must have lasted through those twenty years.

Following Candrakīrti and Nāgārjuna, Tsongkhapa holds that the self is neither the same as the body-and-mind components (the *skandhas*) nor separate from them:

- The self is the **mere I** (*nga tsam*): an agent labelled in dependence on a stream of changing physical and mental components.
- The child in an old photograph is not identical to you today. But nor is that child an unrelated stranger.
- The word "I" reliably links those stages across the decades. The mere I keeps its word, pays its debts and meets the results of its past actions, **while it cannot be found when we search for it with ultimate analysis**.

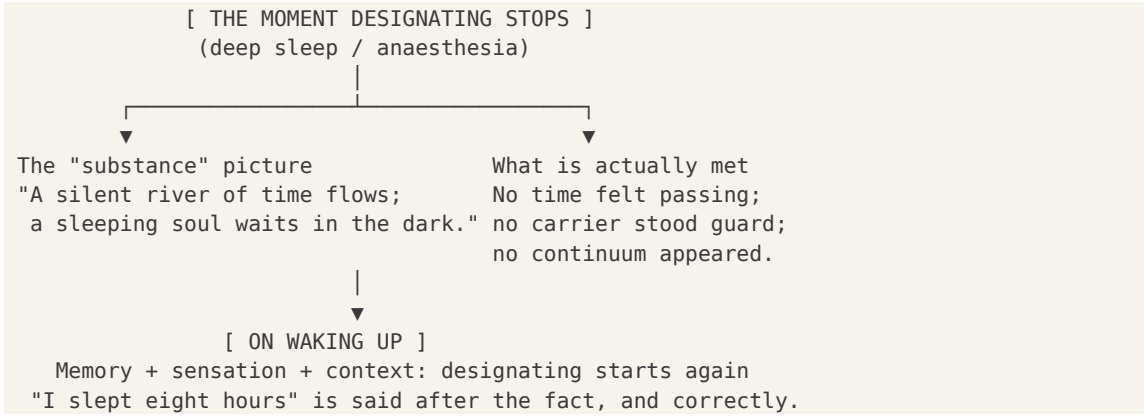
2.2 Continuity Is a Working Agreement, Not a Substance

The mere I has no substance of its own. It exists as a label that works within everyday dealings (*vyavahāra*). Its continuity is real and reliable in the way a treaty or a currency is real. It coordinates what people do and it has consequences, yet you cannot pull out an ounce of stuff called "a dollar" or "the self".

3. The Test Question: What Happens When No One Is Designating?

To loosen our instinctive belief that continuity is an objective background that stands by itself, ask:

"If continuity exists from its own side, what happens to it when the ability to designate is absent?"



3.1 Anaesthesia: No River, No Passenger

Think about general anaesthesia, or sleep without dreams:

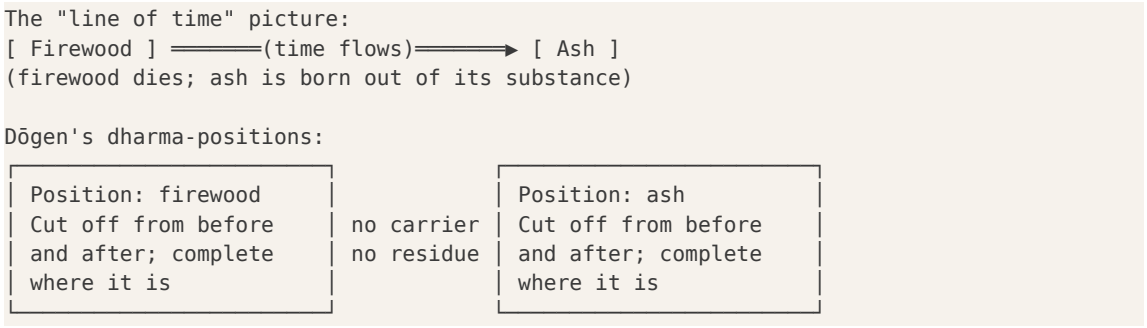
- Three hours pass on the operating-room clock. For the patient, **no time is felt passing at all**.
- The "substance" view imagines time as a dark river carrying a switched-off spectator, like an unconscious passenger in a boat.
- But look closely at the experience itself: **no river appeared**. No dark corridor was walked through. No stretch of time was sat through.
- Where was "continuity" during those three hours? From the side of direct experience, it did not *appear*. That is not the same as saying it did not exist. The world's convention (the clock, the surgeon, the hospital record) says she was under for three hours, and Tsongkhapa's three tests for what exists conventionally accept that.
- On waking, memory, the room and the clock come together, and she says: *"I was asleep for three hours."*

Her own continuity is labelled after the fact, but it is not made up after the fact. "A secret persistence" and "a real break" are the two extremes to avoid (MMK 15.10). In everyday terms the continu ity holds. Under analysis it is not found, and neither is the patient who wakes up.

3.2 Dōgen's "Dharma-Positions": Cut Off, Yet Fully Present

In the *Genjōkōan*, the Zen master Dōgen takes apart the picture of time as a line that flows:

> "Firewood becomes ash, and it cannot become firewood again. Yet one should not take the view that ash is after and firewood is before... Firewood abides in the dharma-position of firewood, which has a before and an after and yet is cut off from before and after. Ash abides in the dharma-position of ash, which has a before and an after and yet is cut off from before and after."



When designation is not stringing moments together along a timeline:

- **Each appearance is complete in its own place.** Winter does not "become" spring. Life does not "turn into" death.
- **Experience flows smoothly because nothing is left over.** Experience is smooth rather than jarring. That is not because a sticky soul carries sensations from one room to the next. It is because **nothing persists** to rub or catch. A sound ends cleanly without dragging over into seeing. Seeing arises freshly from its own conditions.

4. Designation Seen as Conventional and Empty

The aim is not to stop designating. It is to **see what designating is**. What changes when we recognise designation as conventional and empty?

THE HABIT OF MAKING IT SOLID (continuity as a built-in fact)	DESIGNATION SEEN AS EMPTY (continuity as dependent designation)
• Time is a real container	• Time is a labelled relation
• Experience is a possession	• Appearances belong to no one
• Death is a catastrophic loss	• Death is conditions dispersing
• Trauma and flaws are built in	• Patterns change as far as their conditions allow
• Dread of being wiped out	• Vivid presence, owned by no one

4.1 The Habit: Why We Suffer

Suffering (*duḥkha*) comes from treating a label as if it were a built-in property of the world.

- We label ice "cold", then imagine the cold sits inside the ice from its own side.
- We label the stream of body and mind "self", then imagine a real owner standing behind experience who possesses consciousness.
- Because we treat experience as a possession, **we expect death to be a robbery**: the dread that this vivid afternoon, this room and this sense of being will be taken from the one who holds them.

4.2 Seeing Through It: No Owner, Nothing Owned

When continuity is seen as dependently designated:

1. **The owner is gone.** There never was a central someone holding awareness. Experience happens without a landlord.
2. **The possession is gone.** Appearances are not goods kept in a warehouse. A sound is vivid, ringing, and immediately gone. A thought arises and leaves no footprint.
3. **The fear of death loses its target.** Death cannot rob an owner of experience, because no owner ever had it. Death is the scattering of one particular set of conditions: a candle burning down whose light was never anyone's property. Nothing is carried over, and nothing is cut off. Karma, and the way present conditions shape what follows, are still affirmed in everyday terms.

4.3 Room to Change: The Freedom of Continuity Without a Carrier

If continuity rested on a built-in carrier:

- A traumatic past would be carved into your very essence.
- A neurotic pattern or a bitter grudge would be a fixed part of who you are.

Because continuity is **designated across dependent conditions**, nothing is anchored to a permanent bedrock:

- A habit can soften.
- A character can renew itself.
- A grudge can end.

This freedom has limits. A continuity can change exactly as far as its conditions allow, and no further. It is more reliable than the nihilist imagines, because conditions work strictly. And it is less fixed than the believer in substance can allow.

5. Summary Table: Three Levels of Understanding

Question	1. Mistaking things as solid (*avidyā*)	2. Designating stops (sleep, anaesthesia)	3. Designation seen as empty (*prajñapti*)
What continuity is	A river that exists apart from minds and carries things along.	No continuum appears to this stream; in everyday terms it is not wiped out. Under analysis, none is found in either case.	A valid everyday label with nothing underneath it.
What the self is	A fixed carrier (*ātman*, a permanent soul, a core in the brain).	No sense of self is at work; appearances, if any, belong to no one.	Tsongkhapa's **mere I**: it works, it is accountable, and it is empty of any nature of its own (*svabhāva*).
Breaks (sleep, death)	Fear of being wiped out; dread that the container will break.	No time felt passing; no passenger in the dark.	Free of both "it lasts forever" and "it is simply destroyed"; conditions come together and scatter.
How one lives	Rigid identification, grasping, trauma taken as essence, defensiveness.	Direct presence, without any story laid over it.	Change within what conditions allow, natural responsiveness, responsibility without fixation.
Luminosity	Mistaken for a cosmic consciousness or an eternal witness.	Not a witness that stays awake in the dark.	The knowing clarity of appearing itself, empty just as the appearing is; not a nature behind it.

Conclusion

Continuity was never a ready-made fact waiting to be discovered. It is a designation that holds across dependent conditions, and as a designation it is fully valid.

When no one is designating, no continuum appears and none is found, yet nothing is wiped out of everyday existence. Only the phantom river was never there. When designating starts again, it is recognised for what it always was: a flexible, working convention. It makes action, kindness and communication possible, without tying the mind to an illusion of permanence or to the terror of death.